

CORE FORMULA

Understand -> ask their mode -> ask permission -> give one concise idea -> hand back the choice -> check how it landed. -> That sounds exhausting. Do you want me to just listen, or would it help if I offered one possible way to approach it? -> I have one thought, but I don't want to jump into fixing mode. Would it be useful? -> Would you like my honest take, or are you mainly wanting to vent right now? -> One option, if useful, would be X. But you know the situation better than I do. -> Take this or leave it - I wonder whether the easiest first step is X.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Ask before you advise: 'Would it help if I offered one thought?'

BEST FOR

- When someone is venting and you are not sure whether they want advice.
- When you have a useful view but the relationship matters more than being right.
- When a person seems ambivalent, overwhelmed or defensive.
- When you want to help without becoming patronising.
- Coaching, friendship, leadership, mentoring, dating and social support, and conflict repair.
- Digital or text situations, where unsolicited advice can sound harsher than intended.
- After validation, reflection or a summary check, when the person seems ready for input.

PHRASE BANK

Quick permission · Quick & text asks

- "Do you want my take, or should I just listen?"
- "Would it help if I shared one thought?"
- "Are you wanting ideas, or mainly space to vent?"
- "Can I offer one option, or not helpful right now?"
- "Do you want my take or just a sympathetic ear?"
- "I have one thought if useful - no need if you're just venting."
- "Would practical ideas help right now?"
- "Happy to just listen, but I can also suggest a next step."

Warm and supportive · Warm and supportive phrases

- "That sounds like a lot. Would it be useful if I helped you think through options?"
- "I can see why this has been weighing on you. Do you want my perspective, or just company with it for a minute?"
- "I have a thought, but I don't want to steamroll what you need right now."
- "Do you want comfort, thinking-it-through, or practical next steps?"
- "I can stay in listening mode, or we can problem-solve together. What would help?"

Professional / leadership · Professional / leadership phrases

- "Would it be useful if I shared a possible next step?"
- "I can give you a quick view, if that would help."
- "Would you like feedback, or are you still mapping the issue?"
- "One suggestion, if you're open to it, is to sort out sign-off first."
- "Can I offer a framing that may make the decision easier?"

Conflict / resistance · Conflict / resistance phrases

- "Before I offer a view, I want to make sure I've understood the concern."

- "Would it be useful if I suggested a way to make this less frustrating?"
- "I don't want to talk over the concern. Are you open to one idea?"
- "If you're not looking for suggestions yet, that's fine. I can stay with understanding it."
- "I have a possible path, but I want to check whether you want that now."

High-status / busy person · High-status / busy person phrases

- "Would a quick outside read help?"
- "I can offer a concise view if useful."
- "One possible lens, if welcome, is the cost of doing nothing."
- "Would you like a recommendation, or just the key trade-off?"
- "I can keep this to one suggestion."

Shy / guarded person · Shy / guarded person phrases

- "No pressure, but would it help to hear one possible option?"
- "I won't push advice. I can just listen if that's better."
- "Would ideas be useful, or would that feel like too much right now?"
- "Take this only if it fits, and ignore it if it doesn't."
- "We can leave the advice part for later if you want."

Dating / social · Dating / social phrases

- "Do you want my sensible answer or my supportive-friend answer?"
- "Do you want me to be helpful, or just outraged on your behalf for a second?"
- "I have a thought, but I don't want to ruin a good vent."
- "Would a suggestion help, or are we in emotional-support mode?"
- "One gentle take, if you're open to it..."

After you already jumped in · Repair after over-advising

- "Sorry, I went straight into fixing. Do you actually want advice right now?"
- "I think I skipped the listening part. Let me back up."
- "That was more advice than you asked for. What would be useful from me here?"
- "I may have jumped ahead. Do you want me to just understand it first?"
- "Let me stop solving for a second. What's the part that matters most?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: You should just tell them.
Better: Would you like a suggestion?
Best: That sounds frustrating. Do you want me to just listen, or would one possible next step help?
- Weak: Have you tried setting boundaries?
Better: Can I offer one idea?
Best: One option, if useful, is to define the single boundary you most want before the conversation.
- Weak: You're overthinking it.
Better: Maybe think about the timing.
Best: The part that seems most actionable is the timing. But you know the dynamics better than I do.
- Weak: Let me tell you what to do.
Better: Want my honest take?
Best: I can give a concise read if you want it, but I don't want to push advice if you're still processing.

DECISION TREE

If They say yes

Give one concise suggestion, tie it to their situation, then check fit.
"One option, if useful, is X. What do you make of that?"

If They say no

Accept it cleanly and stay in listening mode.

"All good. I'll just listen."

If They say 'maybe'

Offer a very small, easy-to-refuse option.

"I can give one quick thought, and you can ignore it if it doesn't fit."

If They become defensive

Stop advising and validate the concern first.

"Fair enough. Let me make sure I've actually understood it."

If They say they already tried that

Ask what happened rather than pushing a new solution.

"Ah - what happened when you tried?"

If They ask you directly what to do

Answer clearly, but keep the decision and the context theirs.

"If it were me, I'd do X - but you know the full picture."

SCENARIOS

Casual / social - a friend vents about work

Offer ideas or company, and let them choose which. — "That sounds exhausting. Do you want ideas, or are we just letting this be annoying for a minute?"

Professional - a colleague describes a stuck project

Check whether they want input or are still mapping it out. — "Would it be useful if I suggested a possible next step, or are you still mapping it out?"

Leadership - a team member brings a problem

Name the modes on offer and let them pick. — "Do you want coaching, a recommendation, or just a sounding board first?"

Conflict - they are frustrated with you

Understand the concern before proposing anything. — "Before I suggest anything, I want to make sure I've understood. Are you open to one possible way forward?"

Digital / text - a long frustration message

Offer the choice in one short, warm reply. — "That sounds like a lot. Do you want my take, or should I just be on your side for a bit?"

Shy / guarded - they seem uncertain

Keep it low-pressure and genuinely optional. — "No pressure, but would one possible option help?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- There is an urgent safety or operational issue that needs direct action now.
- They explicitly asked for advice and are clearly ready for it.
- You have not understood the situation well enough to advise.
- The issue is really your boundary or request, not their problem to solve.
- A power imbalance means their 'no' would not be truly safe to say.
- You are asking permission only to satisfy yourself before lecturing.
- They are emotionally flooded and need containment or validation first.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Notice the urge

Through the day, catch three moments where you wanted to give advice. Write down what you nearly said - but don't say it.

Day 2 — Write the permission check

For each of yesterday's three moments, write the one-line permission question you'd ask instead, e.g. 'Want my take, or should I just listen?'

Day 3 — Learn the three modes

Practise offering the choice between listening, thinking-it-through, and suggestions. Draft one line that names all three and

say it aloud until it sounds natural.

Day 4 — Shrink the advice

Take an issue you genuinely have advice about and cut that advice to a single concise sentence. If it needs a second paragraph, it needs another permission check.

Day 5 — Use it live, once

In one real conversation, ask permission before advising and give only one idea. Afterwards, ask yourself whether a 'no' truly felt available to them.

Day 6 — Hold a clean 'no'

When someone declines or says 'maybe', respond with real acceptance ('All good, I'll just listen') and hold it - no sliding the advice back in.

Day 7 — Recover on purpose

Replay a moment where you jumped into fixing, and practise the repair line out loud: 'Let me back up - what would actually be useful from me here?'

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I ask before advising, or did I just start solving?
- Was my wording shorter than my instinct?
- Could they have said 'no' and had it genuinely land?
- Did I give one idea, or slide into a lecture?
- Did I hand the decision back to them at the end?